

CYBER CAMPUS

Scrap, poke, upload photographs and become best friends with people you have just met. Indian versions of Facebook are here to stay.

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Vikas Verma reads the newspaper everyday. Along with the news he also flips through the events in town and the best shopping deals. But if it wouldn't have been for ilaaka, a social networking website meant only for Indian net users, this Pune-based software professional would have lost out on a fantastic offer. He's now glad that along with his Orkut profile, he also logged on to its Indian peer. A travel website on ilaaka had listed an offer of a free digital camera to all those buying return tickets to Delhi.

Ilaaka, however, isn't the only one. In the last one year, the Indian cyberspace has been bombarded with several social networking sites. They provide features such as forming groups, uploading photos, sending messages, writing blogs and, of course, the very popular wall (which allows you to post public messages)—all available only for an Indian Internet user.

The reason is fairly simple. After the stupendous success of international sites like Orkut and Facebook, entrepreneurs realised that social networking—a fad fast fading in the West—was a goldmine waiting to be explored in India. Thus were born BigAdda, a Reliance initiative, Yaari, ApnaCircle, Minglebox, Jhoom, ibibo, Desimartini, ilaaka and a bagful of other clones enticing you to scrap, poke and become best friends with people you have just met. "The world is becoming a smaller place and people want to connect with those around them," says 35-year-old Yogesh Bansal, who launched ApnaCircle in September 2007.

So even within the larger social networking space, there are smaller groups, where people with similar interests bond or log on. While BigAdda banks heavily on Bollywood groups, the latest one being for Farhan Akhtar's debut film *Rock On* (Akhtar has also formed a *Rock On* group on

Facebook), ilaaka, which is more local in nature, has a group in Bangalore for parents with children under five, and an unexpected one in Lucknow, where members plan to organise a drag race depending on the online group's success. But most groups on Indian websites revolve around films, cricket or television shows.

Connecting with their kind aside, Indian entrepreneurs have realised the potential of these sites as a platform where single 20-somethings can meet and eventually date, especially in small towns where opportunities for meeting the opposite sex are few and far between. Desimartini even has a separate section called love calculator, where members can calculate compatibility. But, Prerna Gupta, 26, and Parag Chordia, 32, founders of Yaari, realised that random profile posting alone was not going to work. To make people come back to their site, they had to cash in on this dating game but in a better way, as Orkut had already gobbled a substantial slice of the pie. "We want to build a space where people get to know each other through a more meaningful interaction than just want-to-be-friends," says Gupta, whose website today has one million members and features a section where users can rate a guy or girl hot or not. Based on the same concept is Minglebox's Cool Minglers where most active users are selected to be part of this section.

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